Circle of Friends

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The Circle of Friends approach is a method of supporting individual children by harnessing the power of the peer group.

Circle of Friends ~ misnomer?

- The purpose is to elicit understanding in the children and make it more likely that the isolated child will be included and less likely to show behaviours of distress.
- It is NOT about the children becoming the child's friend but making friendly suggestions and being helpful

First steps

- Cognitive and emotional skills
- Old enough to reflect on their own and other children’s behaviours.
- Likely to remember the issues discussed and the strategies discussed.
- Parents and the child in question understand the process and have given permission.
- Ed Psych/SENCo

Process

- A whole class meeting taken by the EP with the other children but without the target child (about 40 minutes)
- Subsequent weekly meetings of a small group, with the target child and with a staff member present to review progress and discuss new strategies (about 15 minutes)

The whole class meeting

- This meeting and the subsequent meetings begins and ends with a game for a few minutes.

- Three sheets are prepared

~Fred’s strengths

~Fred’s difficulties

~Circles in our lives

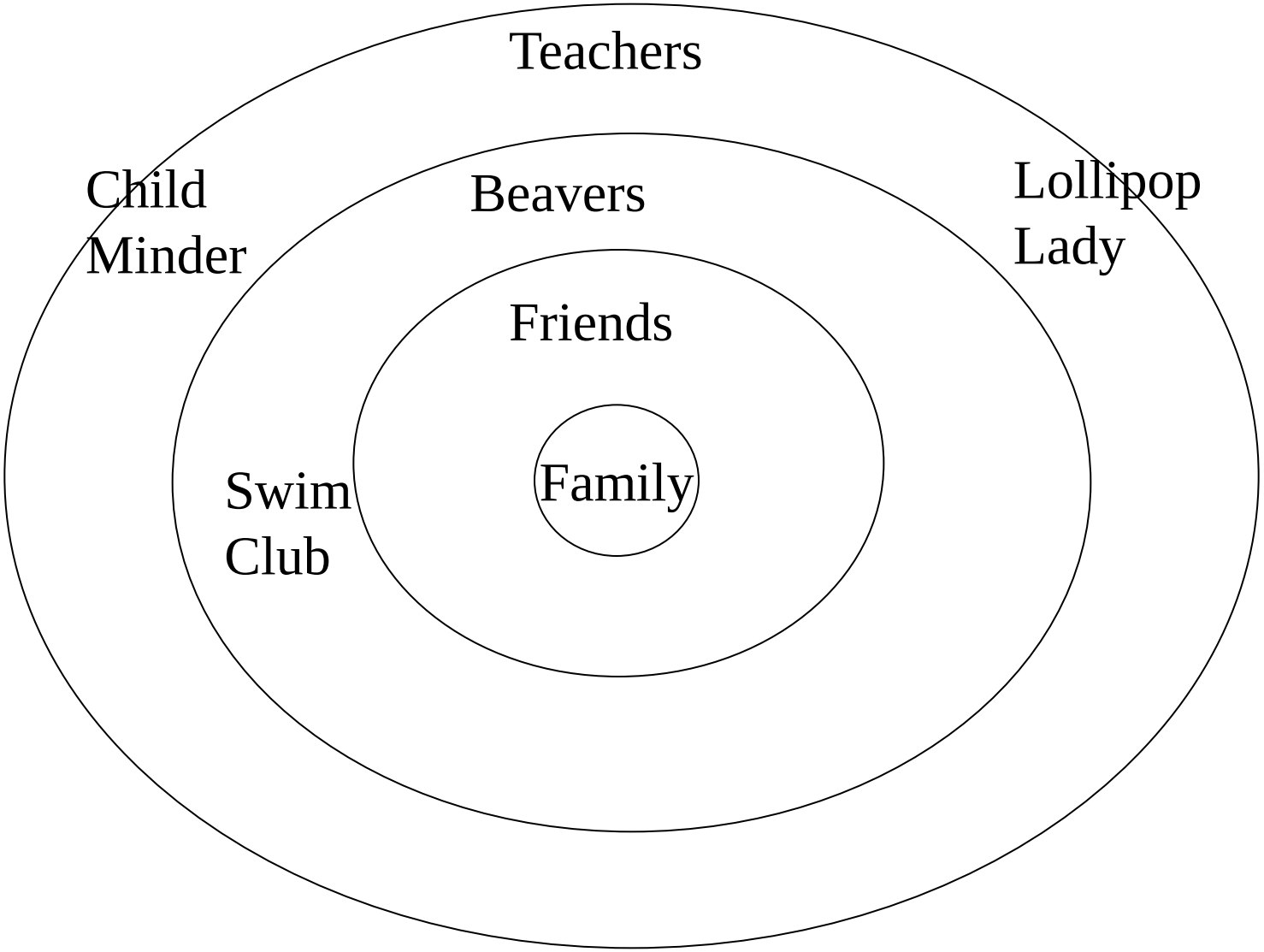
Fred’s strengths

- These are elicited from the children and written on a flip chart.
- Adults present can prompt the children on suitable responses but they usually have no difficulty in coming up with these e.g. Shares his things, has a good sense of humour, is good at maths

Things that Fred find’s difficult

- A second list is compiled, again elicited from the children on things that Fred find’s difficult. These are phrased in a suitable way and put onto a flip chart.
- The children are reminded that Fred and his parents have given permission and that we are discussing this to help Fred.
- Contributions might include, loses his temper, pushes in the line, took my sweets.

The circles in our lives



The psychology bit

- It is explained to the children that sometimes, when people are doing things that are hurting other people, it is because they don’t feel so good themselves and they may not feel that they have friends.
- It is suggested that maybe some of the things Fred has difficulty with are because he does not feel that he has many friends.
- **THIS IS THE MOST IMPORTANT PART!**
- It is important not to rush this part and to create empathy in the class towards the target child.

Eliciting support

- The children are asked to think of ways in which Fred could be helped.
- They are then invited to be part of a support group which would meet each week for a short time with Fred and a staff member to see if they can think of ways of supporting Fred and each other.

The weekly meeting

- Game to begin
- Target child asked ‘What has gone well’
- Other children invited to contribute
- All children asked whether there have been any difficulties
- All asked to think of any ideas that might help
- Suggestions taken ~ all thanked
- Game to end

Safety measures

- Contact with home to ensure that parents are happy with process, and they **fully understand** what a circle of friends is and that the target child is benefitting throughout
- Ensuring that the process has a definite end
- Making sure the group are emotionally safe and not taking on too much
- Making sure that there is an element of fun.

Supplementary ideas

- SEAL ~Getting on and falling out section
- Befriender systems – older children
- Buddy bench
- Group buddy system
- Lunchtime clubs- structured activities- craft clubs, running a tuck shop.
- Safe places/drop-ins during lunch and break times

Evaluating progress

- Comments from the group, child, class teacher and/or child's parents
- Sociograms
- Questionnaires

Psychological Theory

- Maslow's hierarchy of needs
- Humanistic psychology
- Dodge's model of social interaction
- Social learning theory

Any questions?